MELATI WIJSEN, *Author & Founder, Youthtopia*

TOWARDS A GREEN FUTURE

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Policy is not enough. The real challenge is implementing laws and changing everyday behaviour**
- **Change can't happen without a diverse team of differing opinions and skills that complement those of the leader**
- **There has to be space for failure because it helps refine strategies and build resilience**



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Few can claim to effect policy change at the topmost levels of government before turning 20. Melati Wijsen, climate activist and author of *Change Starts Now: 100 Lessons from a Full-Time Changemaker*, is one of those distinguished achievers. Beginning her crusade at the tender age of 12, when she and her sister launched the Bye Bye Plastic Bags campaign in Bali, she reflected on her journey becoming a global icon for the environmentalism movement at the India Today conclave. What started as a small youth initiative led to Bali banning single-use plastic in 2019.

Wijsen emphasised that activism is a long-term process, which includes learning from failure and refining strategies. "It took many years and a lot of collaborations with organisations and like-minded people before we finally passed the law," she said. Implementation, she then added, remains a challenge in Bali, where plastic bags are still used widely. This experience made her shift focus from policymaking to influencing mindsets as well. ■

As a 25-year-old changemaker, I focus a lot on the power of changing mindsets and behaviours in addition to effecting policy change

My sister and I saw the problem of plastic pollution and refused to wait until we were older or had graduated high school to take action